Rise of the conciliators

The conciliators, led by Rao, determined India's Afghanistan policy output in 1992. Despite the previous Congress party government, under Rajiv, having supported Najibullah, the Congress under Rao took a radical departure from the past. Reasons for such a conciliatory policy shift were many, and not just because India was facing multiple crises. Firstly, in 1991, Najibullah had accepted to reconcile with the Mujahideen under Sevan's five-point plan, denounced the remaining Soviet forces in Afghanistan, and converted the PDPA to the *Hezb-e-Watan Party* with strong Islamic symbolism. With Najibullah changing tone and the international community supporting the change, New Delhi had little choice but to accept engagement with the Mujahideen both in principle and practice. In a déjà vu of sorts, New Delhi conceded to politically engage the Taliban in 2011 at the request of the then-president Hamid Karzai and the changing beliefs among coalition forces that such a dialogue was necessary given the ineffectuality of the military option in containing the insurgency. Through 1991–96, India delivered medical aid and food supplies to Afghanistan under the UN Assistance Mission, similar to its aid policy after 2001.[53] Notwithstanding Najibullah's evolving approach, pressure had been building within India to change its Afghanistan policy ever since Gorbachev announced his intention to withdraw Soviet troops.

As mentioned in the previous chapter, the news of Soviet withdrawal shifted India's policy debate from the 'non-alignment versus pro-Soviet' framework to survival mode. Indian parliamentarians' concerns about the safety of Indian citizens and the Hindu and Sikh minority communities across Afghanistan, was a critical factor that shifted India towards a conciliatory, or even a defensive, approach. New Delhi was essentially debating ways to exist in an Afghanistan where a dominant Pakistan was vigorously pushing India out.[54] In this light, speaking in March 1989, Subramanian Swamy, a Janata Party leader, called for urgent reformulation of India's Afghanistan policy, which 'had been one of failure'.[55] With the Soviet Union having withdrawn from Afghanistan, India needed to 'undertake initiatives so that they don't become as isolated as they have been in the recent past' argued Swamy. Saudi Arabia and Pakistan had recognised